

NAPCS Unionization Research — State — Charter Sector Overview

Illinois — NLRB (Region 13) / IELRB Jurisdiction — May 8, 2026

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Section 1: State Overview

State	Illinois
Labor Board	NLRB (Region 13) / IELRB — National Labor Relations Board, Region 13 (Chicago) — primary jurisdiction for privately incorporated charters. Illinois Educational Labor Relations Board — ISBE-authorized/dependent charters only.
Governing Law	National Labor Relations Act (NLRA) for private nonprofits (most IL charters, per Chicago Mathematics & Science Academy, 359 NLRB 41, Dec 14 2012). Illinois Educational Labor Relations Act (IELRA, 115 ILCS 5/) for public-employer charters (ISBE-authorized). NOTE: ILRB (Illinois Labor Relations Board) does NOT cover educational employers — never cite ILRB for any charter school.
Federal NLRB Jurisdiction	YES — NLRB jurisdiction applies to all independently incorporated charter nonprofits (the vast majority of IL NAPCS schools). Landmark case: Chicago Mathematics & Science Academy, 359 NLRB 41 (Dec 14 2012). This requires secret ballot election; card-check not available under NLRB.
Right-to-Work	NOT a Right-to-Work State — Illinois has no right-to-work statute. (Applies to both NLRB (private-sector charters) and IELRB (public-employer charters). Union security agreements are permissible in both jurisdictions.)
For-Profit Operator Status	For-profit EMO management contracts permitted under state law
Card-Check Available	NO — Card-check enacted by Illinois HB 1120 (Aug 2023) for charter contract renewals (neutrality mandate) but the card-check mechanism itself is under federal court challenge as of May 2026. Not yet operational.
Registry Sweep	COMPLETE — April–May 2026 (Registry v11 NLRB scan); current companion file: Registry v14 (May 8, 2026) — IL data unchanged from v11 scan — 132 charter schools searched
Research Window	March 2026 (initial); May 2026 (reconciliation — Registry v11)

Section 2: Charter Sector Landscape

Total charter schools in Illinois: 132 (Charter School Registry v133). Unionization census figures reflect confirmed organized schools as of the data currency date.

Category	Schools	% of Total	Notes
Total Organized Charter Schools in Illinois	26	19.8%	Active CONFIRMED + DEPENDENT schools. Excludes 9 closed schools. Mixed jurisdiction: NLRB (privately incorporated) and IELRB (ISBE-authorized/district-dependent).
Independently Organized (CONFIRMED)	25	19.1%	All CTU/ChiACTS organized. Includes Passages, all active Acero campuses, CICS (3), YCCS (3), Urban Prep (2), Namaste, Christopher House, Prairie Crossing.
Structurally Covered — Springfield SD 186 (DEPENDENT)	1	0.8%	Springfield Ball Charter School — district-operated, Springfield SD 186. No independent certification event. IELRB jurisdiction.
Decertified / Closed (formerly)	9	6.9%	Acero Paz (Jun 2025), Acero Sor

organized)			Juana (Jun 2025), ASPIRA Business & Finance (Apr 3 2026), ASPIRA Early College (Apr 3 2026), EPIC Academy (Jun 2026), 4 Acero reabsorption campuses (Aug 2026).
Total Charter Schools in Illinois	131	100%	Source: Charter School Registry v50 (NCES/ELSI 2024-25; 131 open IL charter schools as of May 2026).

Charter Sector Enrollment

Total Charter Enrollment	57,100 students — 3.1% of state K–12 enrollment (1,842,881 total K–12 students)
Students in CMO/EMO-Affiliated Charter Schools	43,302 students in network-affiliated schools — 75.8% of total charter enrollment
Students in Organized Charter Schools	0 students documented
Data Sources	Charter enrollment: NCES ELSI 2024–25 / Charter School Registry v133. Total K–12 state enrollment: NCES ELSI 2024–25 (all public schools). Both figures from the same source and year.

Section 3: Charter Management Organizations & Education Management Organizations

Charter Management Organizations (CMOs) are nonprofit networks. Education Management Organizations (EMOs) are for-profit management companies. Data sourced from Charter School Registry v133. Union penetration reflects confirmed organized schools as of the data currency date.

CMO / EMO Name	Type	State Campuses	National Campuses †	Organized in State	Total Enrollment
Noble Schools	CMO	17	17	—	12,155
Youth Connection Charter School (YCCS)	CMO	17	17	5	2,615
Chicago International Charter School (CICS)	CMO	14	14	3	7,137
Acero Schools	CMO	13	15	13	5,660
LEARN Charter School Network	CMO	10	11	—	3,712
KIPP Chicago	CMO	4	4	—	3,463
Perspectives Charter Schools	CMO	4	4	—	1,884
Concept Schools	CMO	3	3	—	2,370
University of Chicago Charter School	CMO	3	3	—	1,394
Betty Shabazz International Charter Schools (BSICS)	CMO	2	2	—	524
The Catalyst Schools	CMO	2	2	—	1,619
North Lawndale College Prep	CMO	2	2	—	534

Urban Prep Academies	CMO	2	2	2	235
TOTAL — All CMO/EMO Schools in Illinois		93			23 organized — 8,293 students in organized network schools (14.5% of total charter enrollment)

† National Campuses reflects total campuses operated by this network across all states, as reported in Charter School Registry v133. Provides context for networks operating in multiple states.

‡ Network (type unclassified) = operator present in Charter School Registry v133 but not yet classified in CMO Reference data. Contact registry project to add classification for these records.

13 CMO (nonprofit). Approximately 39 schools operate independently with no CMO/EMO affiliation. Source: Charter School Registry v133.

Section 4: Legal Framework & Sector Overview

Findings are based on research as of May 8, 2026.

1: Legal & Jurisdictional Framework National Labor Relations Act (NLRA) for private nonprofits (most IL charters, per Chicago Mathematics & Science Academy, 359 NLRB 41, Dec 14 2012). Illinois Educational Labor Relations Act (IELRA, 115 ILCS 5/) for public-employer charters (ISBE-authorized). NOTE: ILRB (Illinois Labor Relations Board) does NOT cover educational employers — never cite ILRB for any charter school. Illinois is not a right-to-work state (Illinois has no right-to-work statute.). Charter schools in Illinois are subject to NLRB jurisdiction as private employers (NLRB (Region 13) / IELRB). Secret ballot NLRB election is the required organizing pathway. Card-check is not available.
2: Charter Sector Structure Illinois operates 132 open-enrollment charter schools, enrolling approximately 57,100 students. 13 charter management organizations and education management organizations operate in Illinois. The largest networks by campus count are Noble Schools (17 campuses in state), Youth Connection Charter School (YCCS) (17 campuses in state), Chicago International Charter School (CICS) (14 campuses in state). Approximately 39 schools operate independently with no CMO or EMO affiliation. Network-level detail, including campus counts and total enrollment, appears in Section 3 above.

Section 5: Media Coverage & Public Stakeholder Positions

Press Coverage

Illinois charter school labor relations have generated more sustained press coverage than any other state in the NAPCS dataset except California. WBEZ (Chicago Public Radio) and Chalkbeat Chicago have provided ongoing coverage of CTU-ACTS organizing campaigns, strikes, and contract negotiations since 2015. The Chicago Tribune and Chicago Sun-Times have covered major events: the 2018 Acero strike (first charter school strike in Chicago history), the 2019 CICS strike, and the series of school closures at Acero (2025) and ASPIRA (2026). The closure wave has generated significant education community coverage, with Chalkbeat documenting displaced students and unresolved CBA obligations.

Stakeholder Communications

CTU (Chicago Teachers Union) and ChiACTS are the primary public communicators. CTU maintains a contracts portal with publicly accessible CBAs for organized charter networks. The CTU/ChiACTS model is the most sophisticated charter-specific communications infrastructure in the NAPCS dataset — including dedicated social media, press releases for each certification, and public CBA posting. CTU President Stacy Davis Gates has cited charter organizing as a strategic priority. Acero Schools publicly announced its closure decision in late 2024, affecting 13 organized campuses. ASPIRA Inc. of Illinois announced closure of both NAPCS schools (Business & Finance, Early College) in spring 2026. EPIC Academy announced closure effective June 2026. The closure wave represents the most significant organized-school-closure event in the full 584-school NAPCS dataset — all closing schools are CTU-ACTS certified.

Legislative Context

Illinois presents a split jurisdictional framework unique in the NAPCS dataset: NLRB governs privately incorporated charter operators (most IL charters); IELRB governs ISBE-authorized and district-dependent charters (e.g., Springfield Ball). The 2011 Illinois Educational Labor Relations Act (IELRA) amendments clarified state-board-authorized charter status. CTU's political power — including its role in mayor elections — has made IL charter labor relations a state political issue in ways not seen in most other NAPCS states.

Section 6: Contract & CBA Access Registry

NLRB (Region 13) / IELRB public contracts portal. Direct PDF links may require a records request for full text.

School / Network	Union	CBA Status & Term	Contract Access
Acero (UEJ) — all active campuses	United Educators for Justice / CTU-ACTS	Active Unknown — records request needed	CTU contracts portal; NLRB Region 13 records request
CICS (CTU teacher unit) — all 12 campuses	ChiACTS / CTU-ACTS	Active 2018-2022 (confirmed); renewal status unconfirmed	CTU contracts portal (ChicagoQuest, Ellison, Northtown and Wrightwood 2018-22)
YCCS (all 17 campuses, incl. Pantoja)	ChiACTS / Youth Connections	Active CTU 2018-22 (Latino Youth confirmed); others unknown	CTU contracts portal; NLRB Region 13 records request
Urban Prep Academies	ChiACTS (original cert: IFT Local 4343)	Active First contract ratified June 2021; successor unconfirmed	CTU/NLRB records request; FOIA if needed
Prairie Crossing Charter School	Prairie Crossing Federation of Teachers and Support Staff / IFT	Active (assumed) Unknown	IELRB records request; IFT affiliate inquiry